Myanmar Food Security Cluster

Strategic Plan 2024-2027

Introduction

Purpose and scope of the plan

The Myanmar Food Security Cluster Strategic Plan 2024-2025 aims to guide the food security response in the country, aligning with the Global Food Security Cluster Strategic Plan 2023-2025 and the existing Myanmar Food Security Cluster Terms of Reference. The plan covers a two-year period and focuses on addressing the immediate food security needs of the most vulnerable populations affected by the ongoing humanitarian crisis, while also working towards building resilience and fostering collaboration across the humanitarian-development-peace nexus.

Alignment with the gFSC Strategic Plan 2023-2025 and Myanmar FSC Terms of Reference

This plan is guided by the four strategic pillars outlined in the Global Food Security Cluster Strategic Plan 2023-2025: Anticipatory Action, Localization, Humanitarian-Development-Peace Nexus, and Communication and Advocacy. It also incorporates the cross-cutting themes of Protection, Gender, and Inclusion; Environment and Climate; and Accountability to Affected Populations. The plan is designed to support the overall vision, mission, and core functions of the Myanmar Food Security Cluster as outlined in its Terms of Reference.

Overview of the current food security situation in Myanmar

Myanmar faces a dire humanitarian crisis, with an estimated 12.9 million people (nearly 25% of the population) experiencing moderate to severe food insecurity. The key drivers of food insecurity include conflict, displacement, rising food and fuel prices, reduced market access, asset depletion, and natural hazards such as Cyclone Mocha. The proportion of food-insecure internally displaced persons (IDPs) is roughly double that of host communities across all affected areas. The ongoing political crisis, initiated on 1 February 2021, has further exacerbated the situation, with reports of disruptions to key transport and supply chains, services, and banking systems.

Strategic Objective 1: Anticipatory Action

Context and challenges specific to Myanmar

Myanmar is highly susceptible to natural hazards such as cyclones, floods, and droughts, which significantly impact food security. Conflict and displacement further compound these risks, making it crucial to strengthen anticipatory action mechanisms to mitigate the impact of shocks on vulnerable communities.

Priority activities and targets

- Develop early warning systems and triggers for anticipatory action in collaboration with relevant stakeholders.
- Preposition food stocks and essential agricultural inputs in high-risk areas.
- Strengthen the capacity of local partners and communities to implement anticipatory action.
- Advocate for increased funding for anticipatory action initiatives.

Partnerships and coordination

The Food Security Cluster will work closely with the UN Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs (OCHA), donors, and other relevant clusters such as Shelter/Health/Nutrition and WASH to ensure a coordinated approach to anticipatory action. The cluster will also engage with development actors and to promote long-term resilience-building initiatives.

Strategic Objective 2: Localization

Context and challenges specific to Myanmar

Local and national NGOs play a crucial role in delivering food security assistance in Myanmar, particularly in hard-to-reach and conflict-affected areas. However, they often face challenges such as limited access to funding, capacity constraints, and security risks.

Priority activities and targets

- Strengthen the capacity of local partners through training, mentoring, and resource sharing.
- Advocate for increased direct funding to local partners and explore opportunities for pooled funding mechanisms.
- Promote the meaningful participation of local partners in decision-making processes, including the Strategic Advisory Group
- Support the development of local partner-led consortia to enhance coordination and access to funding.
- Integrate NGO & CSO in FSC coordination (Strategic Advisory Group + subnational co-coordination)

Partnerships and coordination

The Food Security Cluster will work closely with the Myanmar INGO/NNGO forum and other relevant networks to identify and support local partners. The cluster will also collaborate with the Protection Cluster and the Gender in Humanitarian Action Working Group to ensure that localization efforts are inclusive and adhere to protection principles.

Engaging partners in co-coordination

The Food Security Cluster will actively engage partners at the sub-national levels in co-coordination alongside the lead agencies, FAO and WFP. This will help to ensure that the cluster's activities are well-coordinated and responsive to the needs of affected communities across the country.

Creating a Strategic Advisory Group (SAG)

The Food Security Cluster will establish a Strategic Advisory Group (SAG) at the national level to foster greater ownership among partners and ensure a more democratic and inclusive decision-making process. The group will consist of representatives from UN agencies, INGOs, local NGOs, and other key stakeholders, and will provide strategic guidance and oversight to the cluster's activities.

Strategic Objective 3: Humanitarian-Development-Peace Nexus

Context and challenges specific to Myanmar

The multi-faceted crisis in the form of protracted complex emergency and nature disasters in Myanmar requires a multi-dimensional approach that addresses both immediate humanitarian needs and longer-term development and peacebuilding objectives. However, the complex political and security situation poses significant challenges to implementing nexus approaches.

Priority activities and targets

- Strengthen collaboration with development actors to address the root causes of food insecurity and build resilience.
- Advocate for increased funding for livelihoods support and social protection programs.
- Promote conflict-sensitive programming and explore opportunities for peacebuilding through food security interventions.
- Support the transition from emergency assistance to early recovery and development initiatives, where feasible
- Support the development of nutrition sensitive food security programme

Partnerships and coordination

The Food Security Cluster will engage with development actors such as UNDP, and the World Bank to identify opportunities for collaboration and ensure a coordinated approach to the nexus. The cluster will also work with the Protection Cluster and other relevant stakeholders to promote conflict-sensitive programming and peacebuilding initiatives.

Strategic Objective 4: Communication and Advocacy

Context and challenges specific to Myanmar

The complex and rapidly evolving humanitarian situation in Myanmar requires effective communication and advocacy efforts to mobilize resources, raise awareness about food security needs, and promote adherence to humanitarian principles.

Priority activities and targets

- Develop and implement a comprehensive communication and advocacy strategy for the Food Security Cluster.
- Regularly engage with donors, UN agencies, and other key stakeholders to mobilize resources and support for food security interventions.

- Produce timely and accurate information products, such as situation reports, dashboards, and maps, to inform decision-making and advocacy efforts.
- Collaborate with the Protection Cluster and other relevant actors to advocate for the protection of civilians and adherence to humanitarian principles.

Partnerships and coordination

The Food Security Cluster will work closely with OCHA, the Humanitarian Country Team (HCT), and other clusters to ensure a coordinated approach to communication and advocacy.

Cross-cutting Issues

Protection, Gender, and Inclusion

The Food Security Cluster will mainstream protection, gender, and inclusion across all its activities, ensuring that the needs of the most vulnerable populations are prioritized and that interventions are designed and implemented in a safe, dignified, and equitable manner. This will involve close collaboration with the Protection Cluster, the Gender in Humanitarian Action Working Group, and the Technical Advisory Group on Disability Inclusion (TAG) for inclusion of the Persons With Disabilities (PWD).

Environment and Climate

The Food Security Cluster will promote environmentally sustainable practices and climate change adaptation strategies in its programming, recognizing the critical role that healthy ecosystems play in ensuring long-term food security. This will involve collaborating with relevant stakeholders, such as the Environment and Climate Change Working Group, to integrate environmental considerations into food security interventions. Efforts will be made for better collaboration with FAO & WFP region offices to integrate El Nino in the FSC response plan.

Collaboration with other sectors (Nutrition, Health, WASH, etc.)

In line with the global strategy on Inter-cluster collaboration, the Food Security Cluster will work closely with other relevant sectors, particularly Nutrition, Health, and WASH, to ensure a holistic and integrated approach to addressing the needs of affected populations. This will involve regular coordination meetings, joint assessments, and the development of multi-sectoral response plans.

Accountability to Affected Populations

The Food Security Cluster will prioritize accountability to affected populations (AAP) in all its activities, ensuring that the needs, preferences, and feedback of the people it serves are systematically collected, analyzed, and used to inform programming decisions. The cluster will work with the Myanmar AAP/Community Engagement Working Group to establish and maintain effective feedback and complaint mechanisms, and to promote the meaningful participation of affected communities in the design, implementation, and monitoring of food security interventions.

Cluster Coordination and Capacity Strengthening

National and sub-national coordination mechanisms

The Food Security Cluster will maintain a strong coordination presence at both the national and sub-national levels, in line with the existing Terms of Reference. The cluster will ensure appropriate coordination with all humanitarian partners, national and international NGOs, the Red Cross/Red Crescent Movement, and other international organizations. The cluster will also engage with relevant clusters (e.g., Nutrition, Health, WASH, Protection) and Working Groups (e.g., Cash Assessment) to ensure a holistic and integrated response.

Information management and reporting

The Food Security Cluster will invest in robust information management systems and processes to support evidence-based decision-making and reporting. This will include the regular collection, analysis, and dissemination of data on food security needs, response gaps, and achievements, as well as the development of standardized reporting templates and data visualization tools.

FSC will continue to strictly apply the rules & regulations agreed with members related to information management (Information Sharing Protocol) to ensure anonymity of data thus avoiding compromising partners' safety/security on the ground.

Capacity building for local partners

The Food Security Cluster will prioritize the capacity building of local partners, recognizing their critical role in delivering food security assistance and ensuring the sustainability of interventions. This will involve the provision of training, mentoring, and support on key technical areas such as needs assessment, response planning, and monitoring and evaluation, as well as on cross-cutting issues such as protection, gender, and AAP.

Monitoring, Evaluation, and Learning

Monitoring and reporting framework

The Food Security Cluster will develop a comprehensive monitoring and reporting framework to track progress against the objectives and targets outlined in this strategic plan. This will involve the identification of key performance indicators, the establishment of data collection and reporting systems, and the regular review and analysis of monitoring data to inform decision-making and course correction.

Evaluation and learning initiatives

The Food Security Cluster will commission periodic evaluations of its programs and activities to assess their relevance, effectiveness, efficiency, and impact, and to identify lessons learned and best practices. The cluster will also promote a culture of continuous learning and improvement, encouraging the sharing of knowledge and experiences among partners and the wider humanitarian community.

FSC will implement food security analysis to monitor the evolution of the food insecurity in Myanmar. Such analysis will be implemented once a year at minimum, or when a significant change happens.

Exit strategy

The Food Security Cluster's exit strategy for 2024-2027 establishes a gradual transition from coordination to local leadership induced ownership in Myanmar's complex operating environment, with particular focus on IDPs, returnees, and stateless populations. Working exclusively with partners under guidance and leadership from the CLAs, the FSC-SAG, and gFSC, the FSC will coordinate the strengthening of community-based and locally-led food security response mechanisms, support the transformation of emergency assistance into sustainable food systems through both in-kind and cash-based transfer modalities, and facilitate market linkages between local producers and consumers via market based approaches. The strategy emphasizes protection-integrated, partner-led capacity building in climate-smart agriculture through engagement with TCF Coordination on FSL sector, market analysis, and food security assessment, while maintaining necessary humanitarian response capabilities throughout the transition period, ensuring adherence to humanitarian principles and protection mainstreaming.

Through a phased approach spanning over this strategy period (2024-27), FSC will guide partners in developing local leadership and technical capabilities, moving from foundation-building starting in 2024 to full sustainability by 2027. This includes working with and supporting INGO partners in engaging with and transferring leadership to local organizations, establishing co-leadership arrangements at sub-national levels (2024), and building local partner networks with focus on protection-sensitive programming. Beyond 2027, subject to need, FSC will maintain a light coordination and advisory presence to ensure sustained impact, while comprehensive monitoring and evaluation systems track progress through key performance indicators focusing on local partner management, community resilience, protection mainstreaming, and service delivery quality. This approach aligns with the gFSC Strategy 2023-25 and Myanmar's TCF Strategic Priorities, and bridges humanitarian response with long-term development objectives while maintaining protection centrality throughout the transition process.

Annexes (To be completed)

a. Detailed implementation plan
b. Monitoring and evaluation framework
c. Resource mobilization strategy